

Hack to the Future — How You'll Be Judged

FOR BUILDERS. DEMO DAY, MAY 9, 2026.

We're sharing this so you can focus on the right things. The detailed scoring rubric stays internal — but here's the *shape* of what we're looking for, in plain language.

What we're hiring for

Blostem is using this hackathon to find builders we'd want on the team — people with **product/builder mindset**, who take ownership, ship working things, learn fast, and think clearly about users. Functionality is the floor; mindset is the multiplier.

What we're judging — in plain language

You'll be evaluated across five broad areas. You don't need to game them — building well naturally hits all of them.

- **Does it actually work?** — does your core flow run end-to-end, on real inputs, on the day, without falling over? This is the floor. Without it, nothing else holds up.
- **Do you understand the user?** — can you name a specific person you built for, the moment of friction this hits, and where today's options fall short? Vague user descriptions are a tell.
- **Are your technical choices sound, and can you defend them?** — judging is mostly about *why*. "I picked X because..." beats "I used X." We care less which path you picked than whether you picked it deliberately.
- **How did you behave as a builder?** — did you take ownership, make decisions, unblock yourself when stuck, cut things deliberately, and stay open to feedback in Q&A? This is what carries the most weight overall — quiet builders who explain clearly score just as well as loud ones.
- **Can you explain what you built and why, clearly?** — to a technical judge and a non-technical one, in 90 seconds, without jargon. Switching register matters.

What we're NOT scoring on

These come up but won't move your score. Don't optimise for them:

- Slide deck quality. (You don't need slides.)
- Whether your project is deployed to a public URL — local Streamlit is fine.
- How original the *idea* is. (Topics were assigned; we're judging execution and thinking.)
- Pitch-bro confidence. (Quiet builders score just as well as loud ones if the substance is there.)
- Your college, prior internships, or pedigree.

What this means for Saturday

A few practical takeaways:

Make the demo work first, polish second. A working ugly prototype beats a beautiful broken one. Without working core functionality, the rest collapses with it.

Be ready to talk through your decisions, not just describe features. Most of what we're looking for is the *why* behind your work. "I picked RAG over fine-tuning because..." beats "I used RAG."

Engage with judge questions instead of defending against them. If a judge points out a flaw, the strongest answer is "I hadn't considered that — here's how I'd think about it." Defensiveness costs more than imperfection.

Don't hide the hard parts. When you tell the story of what broke and what you learned, you score on multiple dimensions at once.

Keep the answer to "who is this for?" sharp. A specific persona, a specific moment of friction, and what's wrong with today's solutions is a multi-dimension win.

Format reminder

- 10-minute slot per builder, including Q&A.
- Laptop demo to the panel — no stage, no slides required.
- **The panel for the finale is four judges:** Blostem's founders alongside the program mentors, who are stepping in as judges for demo day. Final score is averaged across the panel, plus a "hire signal" we use for tie-breaks and edge cases.

After the demo

You'll get short written feedback within a week. The "one-line takeaway" each judge writes about you is the most useful thing — that's what we'll review on Sunday morning when deciding who we want to talk to next.

See you Saturday. Build well, explain clearly, stay curious.